
PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

ACCIDENT RATE OF MIG-21s

(Data compiled by the IAF)

1990s

2.89

PER 10,000 FLYING HOURS

2000s

0.27

PER 10,000 FLYING HOURS

The rate of accidents dipped after the induction of Hawk Advanced Jet Trainers. Earlier, the rookie pilots completed their initial training on Kiran trainer jets and then flew the MiGs, which led to major crashes

PRESENT IAF COMBAT FLEET

Required strength: 42 squadrons
Current strength: 32 squadrons



Numbers denote squadrons

*Four more ordered

the mother tongue at the lower primary stage, and even thereafter wherever teachers are available," says an official.

Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma had earlier professed support for teaching medicine and engineering in Assamese in the state, and 10 states have already accepted Indian languages such as Hindi, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi and Bengali as the medium of instruction for engineering courses. So, while Sarma's government wants school students to learn science and mathematics in English, they may eventually end up in institutions where engineering or medicine is taught in regional languages.

Sarma says the decision was driven by a growing demand from students of Assamese medium schools who find it tough to crack engineering and medical entrance tests because "these examinations are conducted in English", though he did not cite any such survey. The National Eligibility and Entrance Test (NEET) for medical courses and the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) for engineering courses, however, are conducted in multiple regional languages, including Assamese.

Dismissing the inference that his government's decision goes against the NEP, Sarma says, "By that logic, all CBSE-affiliated schools violate the NEP, as English is the medium of instruction. We are not abolishing Assamese as the medium of instruction in our schools, just teaching two subjects in English only to help students in their future endeavours." He adds that the decision is based on a suggestion by a high-level committee formed by the Assam government to usher in the implementation of the NEP. The principal secretary of the education department heads the 40-member committee.

THE DECISION TO TEACH MATHS AND SCIENCE IN ENGLISH FROM CLASS 3 IS NOT IN SYNC WITH THE NEP 2020

Critics of the government's decision claim it will undermine the relevance of regional languages in Assam. The state's premier literary bodies such as Asam Sahitya Sabha and Bodo Sahitya Sabha and influential students' bodies such as the All Assam Students Union and All Bodo Students Union have also flayed the decision. Many have also questioned the urgency of taking such a decision instead of focusing on filling up vacancies. By the government's own admission, about 8,000 posts of school teachers are lying vacant across the state and the state cabinet recently approved a proposal of appointing guest teachers as a stop-gap arrangement. Moreover, teachers used to teaching in regional languages will need to be trained for shifting to English. ■